Decision Maker

	Getting into digital photography		Semi-professional applications	
You need	Moderate CCD densities, digital zoom, added functionality like Web cam and video recording		High resolution support, high-density CCD, optical zoom, user-selectable features	
Look for	Resolution support of at least 1280x1024, up to 1.3 megapixels, Web cam support and ability to record AVI or MOV clips, 8 MB memory		Resolution support of at least 1600x1200, a 2.1 megapixel CCD, at least 2x optical zoom, the ability to choose metering, flash and white balance modes, 16 MB memory	
	Price-conscious	**Performance**	**Price-conscious**	**Performance**
The models	Fuji FinePix A101, Kodak EasyShare DX3215	Casio GV-10, Kodak EasyShare DX3215, Fuji FinePix A101	Olympus Camedia C-2, Nikon CoolPix 800, Fuji FinePix A201	Olympus Camedia C-2100 Ultra Zoom, Nikon CoolPix 775, Kodak EasyShare DX3600
Price range	Rs 16,000 to Rs 17,000	Rs 16,000 to Rs 27,000	Rs 18,000 to Rs 20,000	Rs 23,000 to Rs 46,000

photos and also double up as a Web cam, this one does the job. This camera integrates 8 MB of memory, is capable of recording AVI clips and with a very small form factor, is a snap to carry around.

The camera that bagged the Best Performance Award was the formidable **Olympus Camedia C-2100 Ultra Zoom**. With its amazing 10x optical zoom and 27x digital zoom, there was no other camera that even came close to this one. This camera exhibited its pure imaging muscle power with brilliant reproduction of the test scene in terms of resolution, details and colour. Based on a 2.11 megapixel CCD, this camera boasts of a host of options that can let

D-Link DSC-350

the user change settings ranging from metering modes to flash and white balance. At its native resolution support of 1600x1200, it is suitable for applications where you would want to print postcard sized photos at 300 dpi. Especially impressive is the low shutter speed of 16 seconds.

The camera that won the award for Best Value was the **Olympus Camedia C-2**. Sporting a 1600x1200 resolution and a 2.14 megapixel CCD, this camera also had configuration options ranging from five white balance modes to multiple flash and metering modes. This camera did very well in our image tests. Best of all, it was priced very well, bordering on the realm of the sub-2.0 megapixel cameras.

Olympus Camedia C-2100 Ultra Zoom

Gauging by the progress of digital cameras, there is certainly a lot happening. With higher density CCDs, more advanced and longer-lasting battery subsystems, greater functionality, smaller form factors and lower prices, they are going to gain increased acceptance amongst not just professionals, but amateurs as well. While there's a long way to go before digital cameras completely replace conventional cameras, if you're considering buying a digital camera, now is as good a time as ever. Take your pick—there's something for everyone.

DIGIT TEST CENTRE

BUYING TIPS!

Buying? Look out for...

When shopping for a digital camera, many of us go by hype and specifications alone, but there are many other parameters and questions that need to be answered.

Resolution: Resolution is everything. It determines whether the camera is suitable for applications such as Web imaging or print applications (*see box, 'How much Resolution is Enough?'*). Look for a camera that can record images at a resolution of at least 1280x1024 at 72 dpi. The native 72 dpi at which cameras store the images is sufficient for publishing images on the Internet, but at this resolution, you can print only 5.3x4 inch photos at 300 dpi. If you you want to print larger photographs at 300 dpi or more, you need a higher resolution.

Optics: Look for cameras that have an optical zoom; it is much higher in quality compared to digital zoom, since the latter is just a method of enlarging the image the camera sees through software manipulation and the camera's DSP (Digital Signal Processor). Digitally zoomed images often appear pixellated when printed at larger sizes.

Battery: Digital cameras are known for draining batteries very quickly! Go for cameras that bundle Ni-MH or Li-Ion batteries. These will last you much longer than those that use the conventional AA or AAA alkaline batteries.

Memory: The amount of memory that the camera bundles will decide how many photos you can store at a time. Most cameras come with 8 MB or 16 MB of Flash memory that can hold about eight or 16 images respectively at 1600x1200 in the high quality modes. If you have ready access to a laptop or a computer, you can make do with 8 MB, otherwise buy a camera with as much memory as you can afford.